

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Housekeeping and Commercial Cleaning English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Housekeeping attendants, commercial cleaners, custodial staff, and cleaning team members.

All room numbers, buildings, times, counts, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice, not cleaning certification, chemical-use instruction, medical advice, or access authorization. Follow employer training and site procedures for products, equipment, privacy, waste, and hazards. Do not infer permission to enter, mix products, handle unknown waste, or repair equipment. This course addresses frontline cleaning exchanges rather than hospitality management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

access window

An agreed period during which a space can be entered for assigned work.

affected area

The specific location impacted by a reported problem.

assignment sheet

A list identifying the rooms, areas, or cleaning tasks allocated to a worker.

cleaning

Removing dirt and other unwanted material from a surface.

completion record

A record showing which assigned work was actually completed and any relevant limitations.

custody record

A record identifying who received or held an item during its transfer.

discrepancy

A difference between a recorded quantity and the quantity actually counted.

disinfection

A process intended to inactivate specified microorganisms under the product's stated conditions; not synonymous with ordinary cleaning.

do-not-disturb notice

A sign communicating an occupant's request not to be disturbed; entry rules remain site-specific.

found location

The precise place where an item was discovered, separate from where it is later stored.

hazard report

A report describing a condition that may cause harm and needs the appropriate response.

inspection

A check of completed work against the relevant task requirements.

item description

A factual account of a found object's visible identifying features.

linen

Fabric items used in rooms or service areas, such as sheets and towels.

lost property

Items found without their owner present and handled through the site's return arrangements.

maintenance request

A request for the responsible team to assess or repair a building or equipment problem.

occupied room

A room currently in use by a guest or other occupant.

out-of-service notice

A sign identifying equipment or an area as unavailable for use.

outstanding task

Work that has not yet been completed.

par stock

The target quantity of a supply used as a stocking reference.

product label

The information attached to a cleaning product identifying it and its stated use and warnings.

replenishment

Adding supplies to replace what has been used or is missing.

residue

Material left on a surface after use or a cleaning task.

rework

Work repeated or corrected because the first result didn't meet the specified requirement.

room status

The recorded stage of a room's service, such as not started, in progress, or awaiting inspection.

Safety Data Sheet

A document describing a chemical product's hazards and related safety information; often shortened to SDS.

service refusal

An occupant's decision to decline an offered cleaning visit or task.

service scope

The specific cleaning work included in an assignment or agreement.

sign-off

A recorded confirmation by the designated person that a specified check or task meets its requirement.

spot cleaning

Cleaning a particular marked or affected area rather than the entire surface.

streak

A visible line or uneven mark on a surface such as glass.

touchpoint

A surface or item frequently touched by people, such as a handle.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Turn 'everything' into named tasks

My assignment includes ___, but not ___.

When you say ___, which surfaces do you mean?

I'll ask the supervisor whether ___ can be added.

A broad request may contain extra work or items the cleaner should not move. Name the included work and ask about the rest.

Word combinations in this lesson

confirm the assigned area: identify exactly which space belongs to the task

clarify the service scope: check which work is included

prioritize the requested room: agree which assigned space comes first

distinguish a spot from the whole surface: define the extent of a cleaning request

Offer a return window without overriding privacy

Would ___ or ___ work better?

I can return between ___ and ___.

Would you prefer no room service today?

A return appointment and permission to enter are separate. State the available window instead of promising an exact minute you can't control.

Word combinations in this lesson

request permission to enter: ask before entering where permission is required

agree a return time: arrange when to offer service again

respect a declined service: accept the occupant's stated choice

confirm the access window: verify when the room is available for work

Ask for identification, not a guess

The label doesn't let me confirm ____.

I haven't used ____ because ____.

Could you provide the current ____ for this product?

The same color or bottle shape can belong to different products. Knowing a nickname isn't the same as identifying the actual container.

Word combinations in this lesson

identify the product: confirm the exact container and product name

consult the current label: use information for the product actually present

ask for the task standard: clarify what the assignment requires

report missing information: explain which required detail cannot be confirmed

Give the response team useful facts

I observed ____ at ____.

The source hasn't been established.

Who is handling ____, and what should I report about access?

'Water near a door' is less useful than a specific washroom and landmark. Request the appropriate responder rather than offering repair steps.

Word combinations in this lesson

describe the observed condition: say what you saw without inventing a cause

give an exact location: identify floor, room, or nearby landmark

report a recurrence: say that the same observed condition appeared again

keep an area status clear: distinguish cleaned, restricted, and awaiting review

Transfer an item without inventing its owner

I found a ____ at ____.

The owner is not confirmed.

Can you confirm you've received ____?

Finding an item in a room doesn't prove who owns it. Describe the exterior and location without inspecting private contents or publicly disclosing guest information.

Word combinations in this lesson

report a found item: notify the responsible person of an unattended object

describe visible features: state what can be observed without searching private contents

record the found location: preserve where the object was discovered

confirm receipt of the item: verify who accepted the transfer

Give useful counts, not a general shortage

We have ___ against a target of ___.

We're short ___ of ___; ___ is complete.

The delivery is expected, but ___.

Separate item types and distinguish an expected delivery from available stock. A shortfall in one item doesn't mean every linen item is unavailable.

Word combinations in this lesson

count by item type: keep different supplies in separate totals

replenish the dispenser: restore the assigned supply without assuming a different product fits

report the shortfall: state how many items are missing from the target

confirm an allocation: identify supplies assigned to a particular floor or task

Address the result without arguing about effort

Could you show me the exact ___?

I can see the ___ you mean.

I'll ask for a check of ___, not assume ___.

'It was cleaned' doesn't mean every result meets the task requirement. Listen for the exact surface and defect instead of defending how long the task took.

Word combinations in this lesson

acknowledge the specific concern: name the mark or missed area the person reports

ask for the exact location: identify which surface needs attention

check against the task requirement: compare the result with the assigned standard

confirm the correction: ask whether the reported issue has been addressed

Report the stage, not a vague 'ready'

___ is cleaned but awaits ___.

___ hasn't started because ___.

Can you accept the follow-up for ___?

Cleaned, inspected, and released can be separate statuses under a site's arrangements. Do not turn a completed cleaning task into a broader authorization.

Word combinations in this lesson

hand over the remaining area: identify unfinished work and its next owner

distinguish cleaned from inspected: keep task completion separate from a later check

record an access limitation: state what prevented work in a particular area

confirm who takes over: obtain acknowledgment from the receiving worker

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Confirming the assignment and its limits

A commercial assignment says 'conference room: tables and floor.' The client asks for 'everything' before a 3:00 meeting. The worker is assigned table surfaces and the floor, not high windows or personal equipment. The supervisor can clarify extra work; the meeting time doesn't expand permission.

The assignment covers the conference-room table surfaces and floor. When you say everything, are you also asking about the high windows and personal equipment? Those aren't included in my current task list. I can complete the listed work and ask my supervisor to review the additional request before anyone promises it for three o'clock.

Try it again: The client adds laptops to 'tables.' Clarify that cleaning around personal equipment differs from handling it.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Respecting access and occupied spaces

A guest in room 312 declines cleaning at 10:00 because of a call until 11:00. The attendant's return window is 11:15-11:30. The guest can choose a visit in that window or fresh towels at the door now. No room entry is authorized by this conversation alone.

I understand you're on a call until eleven. I can offer a return between eleven fifteen and eleven thirty, or bring fresh towels to the door now if that is all you need. Which would you prefer? I'll record your choice, and we'll still follow the room-access arrangements when I return.

Try it again: The guest says 'after my call' without confirming a time. Offer the actual window again.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Clarifying product and task information

A bottle on the cart has an unreadable label. A colleague identifies it by color, but two products use similar bottles. The cleaner has not used it. The supervisor can identify it and provide the relevant product information or a clearly identified replacement. No chemical steps are taught.

I can't identify this bottle from its unreadable label, and its color doesn't resolve which product it contains. I haven't used it. Could you help confirm the product and its current information, or provide a clearly identified replacement? I need that resolved before I continue the assigned task with this bottle.

Try it again: The colleague offers a nickname. Request the exact product information from the supervisor.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Reporting faults and unsafe access

Water is visible on the floor outside washroom B, beside the east stair door. The cleaner doesn't know the source and has reported it under site arrangements. The supervisor needs an exact location and confirmation that the area has not been declared ready. No plumbing diagnosis or cleanup method is requested.

There is water on the floor outside washroom B, beside the east stair door. I don't know its source, and I haven't marked that area ready. Please arrange the appropriate site response and tell me who is taking the follow-up. I'll report the location and current restriction clearly to the next team.

Try it again: A passerby says the floor was cleaned earlier. Explain why the present water still needs reporting.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Handling found items and privacy questions

An attendant finds a closed black glasses case beneath the chair in room 214 after checkout. The owner is unknown. The attendant should report visible details without opening it and transfer it to the designated lost-property receiver, who can confirm receipt. Don't identify an owner from a guess.

I found a closed black glasses case beneath the chair in room two-fourteen. I haven't opened it, and I don't know whose it is. Could you receive it through the lost-property arrangement and confirm the transfer? Please keep the found location separate from its storage location so any later inquiry uses the correct details.

Try it again: A colleague asks you to name the previous guest in a public area. Keep the inquiry with the designated receiver.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Counting linen and replenishing supplies

The third-floor cart target is twelve bath towels and eight hand towels. The attendant counts nine bath towels and eight hand towels. A laundry delivery is expected but not confirmed. Report the three-bath-towel shortfall without calling all linen unavailable.

The cart has nine bath towels and eight hand towels. Against today's target of twelve and eight, we're short three bath towels; the hand-towel count is complete. A laundry delivery is expected, but its arrival isn't confirmed. Could you check whether three bath towels can be allocated from available stock?

Try it again: Another floor requests two towels from this cart. Explain the effect on its count before any reassignment.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Responding to a quality concern

A client reports streaks on the interior glass panel beside office 8, cleaned earlier that day. The cleaner can acknowledge the reported result and ask the lead to arrange a check and appropriate rework. The cause is unknown; the client is available to point out the panel.

Thank you for showing me the streaks on the interior panel beside office eight. That is the panel on today's completed task list. I'm sorry the result needs attention. I'll ask our lead to check it and arrange the appropriate rework. I don't know the cause yet, so I'll report the visible marks rather than guess.

Try it again: The client says all windows must be poor. Keep the confirmed concern limited to the identified panel.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Giving a clear end-of-shift handover

Rooms 301 and 302 have been cleaned; 302 awaits the supervisor's inspection. Room 303 was inaccessible and not cleaned. The incoming attendant can accept 303's access follow-up, while the supervisor owns 302's inspection. Report each status separately without deciding room release.

Room three-oh-one is cleaned. Three-oh-two is also cleaned, but the supervisor's inspection is still pending. Three-oh-three was inaccessible and hasn't been cleaned. Can you take the access follow-up for three-oh-three? I'll confirm the inspection request with the supervisor; please don't describe that pending check as a completed sign-off or a room-release decision.

Try it again: A caller asks whether 302 can be released. Direct the release question to the responsible person.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Janitors and Building Cleaners

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/building-and-grounds-cleaning/janitors-and-building-cleaners.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Maids and Housekeeping Cleaners

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/37-2012.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

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Lesson 01: Confirming the assignment and its limits

Original fictional case: A commercial assignment says 'conference room: tables and floor.' The client asks for 'everything' before a 3:00 meeting. The worker is assigned table surfaces and the floor, not high windows or personal equipment. The supervisor can clarify extra work; the meeting time doesn't expand permission.

Language workshop: Turn 'everything' into named tasks

Communication goal: Clarify the requested surfaces and the boundary of the current assignment.

Language guidance: A broad request may contain extra work or items the cleaner should not move. Name the included work and ask about the rest.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): My assignment includes ___, but not ___. / When you say ___, which surfaces do you mean? / I'll ask the supervisor whether ___ can be added.

Vocabulary: assignment sheet: A list identifying the rooms, areas, or cleaning tasks allocated to a worker. / service scope: The specific cleaning work included in an assignment or agreement. / touchpoint: A surface or item frequently touched by people, such as a handle. / spot cleaning: Cleaning a particular marked or affected area rather than the entire surface.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: you want table surfaces and floor ready first; windows are an extra request.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The client adds laptops to 'tables.' Clarify that cleaning around personal equipment differs from handling it.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The assignment covers the conference-room table surfaces and floor. When you say everything, are you also asking about the high windows and personal equipment? Those aren't included in my current task list. I can complete the listed work and ask my supervisor to review the additional request before anyone promises it for three o'clock.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Review with supported choices and speaking

1. Ask me to close my notes. Prepare six four-choice questions: two vocabulary gaps, one grammar contrast, one confirmed-versus-unknown distinction, one choice of reply, and one transfer to a clearly labelled fictional variation.
2. Show only the first question. Use a short role-labelled exchange or a concrete scenario, four plausible choices A-D, and exactly one defensible answer. Stop and wait.
3. After each answer explain all options, offer one hint for a retry if needed, and invite me to say the completed exchange aloud. Only then move on. Do not request an original written response.
4. Track whether I answered independently or with a hint, not a certified proficiency score. Do not assess pronunciation from typed text. Replace ambiguous questions and accept valid spoken alternatives.
5. Give a compact review card with three four-choice recall items and a separate answer section. Summarize two specific successes and two points to revisit. Do not claim to remember or schedule future sessions.

END PROMPT